

section two

Attract and Build a Wide Pool of Candidates

CHAPTER 7

Don't Post That Job Listing Before Taking These Five Steps

by Marlo Lyons

In the rush to fill positions, many hiring managers often overlook critical steps when scaling their teams. Without conducting a thorough team assessment before creating job descriptions, they risk ending up with skill gaps. Rather than simply adding headcount, it's essential to take a more strategic approach, understanding which additional skill sets and capabilities will truly add value to the team and organization—both now and in the future.

Here's how to conduct a comprehensive assessment before creating that job description.

Step 1: Strategically align goals

Begin by aligning your team's goals with organizational objectives. While this may seem obvious, it helps you anticipate evolving skill requirements, ensuring that you hire talent that not only meets current demands but also fuels future agility and growth.

For example, imagine your company is moving toward data-driven marketing but isn't quite there yet. That strategic direction will likely require employees to have skills like data analysis and strategic thinking, as well as technical proficiency in digital marketing platforms, social media analytics, and marketing automation tools. Therefore, a marketing leader will want to seek candidates who can demonstrate deep technical skills as well as marketing skills.

Communicate transparently with candidates about future skill needs to ensure that they won't feel underutilized if all their skills can't be leveraged immediately upon hire.

Outcome: Prevents skills mismatches and will ensure the organization is prepared for evolving demands.

Who should be involved: Your leadership team (or entire team if you have a small team), cross-functional stakeholders, and your manager.

Rough time frame: One to two weeks.

Step 2: Conduct talent planning

Conduct a thorough talent assessment to identify both your whole team's and individual members' existing skills and potential gaps.

Individual skills inventories and tools—for example, the 9Box performance assessment, 360-degree assessments, individual development plans, and talent performance reviews—can help you evaluate each

team member's hard and soft skills. This can provide deep insight into which skills and capabilities are missing on your team. Without these insights, you may default to repurposing positions held by long-term employees who lack the skill sets needed for the future but have historical knowledge critical for business continuity.

A SWOT analysis (strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats) can help you identify where your team has excelled and where it has faced challenges while working on previous projects, cross-functional engagements, or organizational changes. Ask cross-functional stakeholders to weigh in on your assessment to ensure that a new hire will fill team gaps in alignment with stakeholders' needs.

Outcome: Ensures your team is skilled and well-equipped to meet current and future challenges, enhancing overall business continuity.

Who should be involved: Your HR partner, your leadership team, and your manager.

Rough time frame: One to two weeks. This can be done concurrently with Step 1.

Step 3: Evaluate team structure

Analyzing the current team structure will help you determine how well it supports your strategic goals and whether existing roles and responsibilities are aligned with the team's objectives. Identify any structural issues that could be addressed by new hires or internal adjustments.

For example, if all of your team managers are considered inexperienced at people leadership, you'll want to hire someone with deep management expertise who can help mentor the novice managers. If your team has work spread across numerous people, thus hampering decision-making, perhaps work needs to be consolidated under one leader, and you may need to hire someone to manage areas that won't be consolidated.

Outcome: Enhances team effectiveness and engagement with an explanation of what hole the new hire will fill.

Who should be involved: Your HR partner and your manager. If you have a large organization, include your leadership team as well.

Rough time frame: Depending on the depth of the organization and its complexity, this could take one month or longer.

Step 4: Identify team cultural nuances

While subject matter expertise, diversity of thought, and technical skills are crucial, ensuring that a candidate can integrate well into the current team will help maintain a harmonious work environment and prevent conflict. Assess your team's unique dynamic to identify which types of personalities have blended into the team well and which have struggled to fit in or be successful. Looking for candidates who can complement the existing team will ensure smooth onboarding and enhance the team's productivity. For example, if your team values close collaboration, a candidate who prefers to work completely independently might create friction that detracts from the work goals.

Outcome: Ensures new hires will seamlessly integrate into team dynamics, leading to smoother onboarding, enhanced collaboration, and increased overall team productivity.

Who should be involved: Your HR partner, your leadership team, and your manager.

Rough time frame: One week.

Step 5: Understand team members' aspirations

This is an overlooked yet critical step before putting together a job description. Employees are more engaged and productive when their aspirations and interests are considered alongside organizational needs. By understanding current team members' values and career interests, leaders can avoid courting new hires with overlapping goals or career interests.

For example, if a leader already has three team members who aspire to manage people, hiring another person with similar ambitions may lead to frustration for them, as they may see themselves as behind the three other tenured team members in line for management opportunities. Conversely, if a seasoned people leader is hired, the three tenured employees may feel they have no room for advancement.

Outcome: Ensures talent development and prevents hiring overlapping skills, thereby reducing potential competition or conflict within the team.

Who should be involved: Your HR partner, your manager, your leadership team for large teams, and for teams over 200 people, consider including the data analytics team to develop a detailed survey.

Rough time frame: This depends on team size—for a small team (up to 10 members), this process may take one to two weeks. For larger teams, it could extend to three to four weeks to hold individual meetings, conduct follow-ups as necessary, and complete analysis of the data.

By embracing a strategic and holistic approach to talent assessment before hiring new employees, companies will be able to uncover additional avenues for growth, optimize team dynamics, and ensure that they bring on board individuals whose capabilities align with the organization's future needs. Ultimately, this proactive approach not only bolsters team effectiveness but also fortifies the organization's resilience by future-proofing its workforce against evolving challenges and opportunities.

Marlo Lyons is a career, executive, and team coach, as well as the award-winning author of *Wanted—A New Career: The Definitive Playbook for Transitioning to a New Career or Finding Your Dream Job*. You can reach her at marlolyonscoaching.com.

Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, June 4, 2024 (product #H088XW).

CHAPTER 8

Write a Job Description That Attracts the Right Candidate

by Whitney Johnson

Far too many organizations miss golden opportunities to bring onboard the best possible talent for the tasks at hand—and those of the future. When it's time to recruit, hire, and onboard, the most common approaches are routine and rote, prone to misjudgment and error. The process is costly and, in the end, unfruitful.

This failure begins early in the process from when the role is conceived to trying to capture it in a written job description. As international talent management expert Dorothy Dalton laments, “Copy-paste recruitment is generally business as usual in most organizations. . . . Even if the post was last filled five years ago, the chance of anyone thinking it might have to be crafted differently are slim. Generally, the only changes I see are to inflate the qualifications.”¹

If you think the job you're hiring for hasn't changed in the last five years—or even in the past year—then it's probably just about the only thing in your organization that hasn't. And the practice of overinflation of job qualifications often discourages desirable candidates from applying—candidates with potential who won't be easily bored in the role.² So instead of leaning on this approach, learn to pinpoint what you really need from a new hire to properly compose and position the job description. Here are four suggestions:

Know what you need now, but also envision the future

Think of the job as an S curve, with lots of room to grow in the role at the low end of the “S” and high proficiency but little potential at the top end. In most cases, I advocate hiring someone who will onboard at the low end and enjoy an enthusiastic and extended growth experience, with a commensurate level of job engagement, satisfaction, and productivity as they ascend the curve to reach high proficiency.

Sometimes, however, you need a sharpshooter with the expertise to solve a pressing problem. You can't wait for them to grow. The trade-off is that they will quickly move on, either to another organization or to a new challenge in yours (if one is available for them), and you will need to hire again, hopefully for a longer tenure.

Before writing the job description, think about what will best serve the organization in both the short and long term. In some cases, it may be more appropriate to contract a gig worker to solve the problem and hire an employee for longer-term growth.

Understand the hiring context

Evaluate the role in the context of the team in a large organization, or in the whole organization if your workplace is on the smaller side. Filling a job is a growth opportunity for the business, not just for the individual; the best fit is found when it captures growth for both. You can better align your job openings and descriptions with what your business needs by better understanding your current roles.

For example, we consulted with a company that had motivated midlevel managers who were nonetheless uncertain about opportunities for advancement. This was especially true for people who had worked in the organization for more than 10 years. As the company developed new jobs to be filled, we recommended that it survey a targeted group of individuals related to the role they were hiring for. In the survey, they asked people to outline what they actually did versus the job description for their role. Questions included: *Why do these differences exist? What has motivated or required them to do things differently than their job description would suggest? What tasks are associated with the standard phrase “and other jobs as specified?” What challenges have they faced and overcome to be successful? How is success gauged—what are the metrics used? And, finally, How long have they been in this role?*

This type of survey can identify roles that need to be trimmed or pruned out altogether. Results can facilitate proper allocation of valuable human resources and help identify opportunities for internal movement and advancement of proven talent. You may even find you don’t need an external hire at all, or that you need to hire for something different than the vacant position. Ultimately, you will be properly informed when writing the job description if you know what current employees are doing and what they *want* to be doing. The gaps will reveal themselves.

Avoid limiting language

As I noted earlier, the goal of a job description is to invite applicants. To do this successfully, avoid limiting language. Gender-biased language, for example, is known to discourage possible candidates, so avoid words that have overly masculine or feminine connotations (such as “competitive” or “nurturing”).
[3](#)

Similarly, careless language can discourage applicants who are not white, who are “young” or “old” (adding quotes because perceptions of age can vary by individuals, cultures, industries, and the like), or whom have unconventional career paths (such as gig workers, on-rampers, or late-career folks). Avoid using terms like “career-oriented” or “experienced” or “energetic” to widen the pool of candidates you appeal to. If you’re trying to diversify your workforce (and I hope you are) then include language specifically inviting diverse interest. Kristen Pressner, the global head of human resources for Roche Diagnostics, advocates that we “flip it to test” our language:^{[4](#)} If you’re a man, how might your language sound to a woman? If you’re white, how might the job description read for a person of color? If you’re a driven career person, would what you’ve crafted invite an applicant who needs to work from home? Also test the language you use with a diverse group of individuals before you post. They can help illuminate your blind spots.

Think about meaning

People want to contribute, to feel energized and passionate about what they do. They want to be inspired by ideas that can help solve problems and meet needs. This doesn’t necessarily mean changing the world or addressing cosmically important issues. But it does mean believing that we are making our corner of the world happier, brighter, and safer in some small but significant way.

It is critical that organizations ensure that the roles they are hiring for are quality opportunities for meaningful work, personal growth, and impact. This needs to be conveyed through the job description and even into the interviewing process. For example, Chatbooks is a company that helps people create printed scrapbooks from their Instagram photos. Rather than focusing on specific skills, they use words like “high-performance creativity,” “grown up,” and “optimistic” to describe their values and the kind of candidates they are seeking to employ. When you hire an individual whose values align with the - purposes of your organization, it’s a win-win. Craft the job description to invite those people to apply.

When you get a job description right, you provide an opportunity for your next employee to assume market risk—to play where others in your organization aren't, utilizing their distinctive strengths. The odds of success are much higher than if they face competitive risk, battling for turf with entrenched players. The right fit means that a new hire has room to grow. And when your employees grow, so does your organization.

Whitney Johnson is the CEO of Disruption Advisors, a change management advisory firm, and the author of *Smart Growth: How to Grow Your People to Grow Your Company*.

Adapted from content posted on hbr.org, March 30, 2020 (product #H05HTC).

NOTES

1. Dorothy Dalton, “Why Copy-Paste Recruitment Fails in Today’s Market,” dorothydalton.com, February 5, 2016, https://dorothydalton.com/2016/02/25/why-copy-paste-recruitment-fails/?utm_source=ReviveOldPost&utm_medium=social&utm_campaign=ReviveOldPost.
2. Whitney Johnson, “If You Are Looking to Hire (or Get Hired), Here Are Some Things to Consider,” LinkedIn, January 23, 2019, <https://www.linkedin.com/pulse/you-looking-hire-get-hired-here-some-things-consider-whitney-johnson/>.
3. Rachel Blakely-Gray, “Is Gender-Biased Language Creeping into Your Job Descriptions?” Top Echelon, February 1, 2019, <https://topechelon.com/blog/gender-biased-language-in-job-descriptions/>.
4. Janine Milne, “‘Flip It to Test It’: Lessons on Battling Bias from Roche,” diginomica, March 18, 2018, <https://diginomica.com/flip-it-to-test-it-lessons-on-battling-bias-from-roche>.